ADVANTAGE CONGRESS

AN INCREASINGLY INTENSE CONGRESS-BJP FIGHT IS PUSHING AN ALREADY BRUISED BRS TO THE SIDELINES

BY AMARNATH K. MENON



Photographs by ANI



FOR A STATE THAT HAS BEEN IN EXISTENCE only for 10 years and is therefore the country's youngest, Telangana is fast becoming the new battleground for hard-fought electoral contests. Just five months ago, it saw the end of the decade-long rule of the Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS), led by the man who had spearheaded the movement for the state itself, K. Chandrashekar Rao (KCR), in a bruising assembly election. The summer may be crueller than November, with political temperatures rising in tandem with the mercury. On May 13, three advancing armies—of the ruling Congress, BRS and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)—will battle for the state's 17 Lok Sabha seats.

The Congress—buoyed by its win in the 2023 year-end assembly election, coming in from a decade's exile—is determined to replicate its success. The BRS, which held the state for two terms but is now plagued by defections, is hoping for a turnaround in electoral fortunes. The BJP, fuelled as much by its improved seat and vote shares as by the way they came, is eager to expand its footprint.

On a roll since its November victory, the Congress is resolutely set on decimating the BRS. Leading its charge is the feisty chief minister, A. Revanth Reddy, also the state Congress chief. Working overtime to demolish KCR's political capital, the party has over the past four months crafted a narrative around how the BRS and its supremo did Telangana a great disservice, parlaying their status as 'founders' into one of 'owners' and running a regime based around corruption and nepotism. In a meticulously nuanced campaign, Revanth first issued white papers, then followed them up with departmental inquiries and judicial probes to uncover the tardy aspects of governance even as the BRS first family was charged with siphoning off huge sums. A judicial probe is on into the lapses in the mammoth Rs 94,000 crore Kaleshwaram Lift Irrigation scheme and alleged phone tapping of political rivals and businesspeople for extortion.

On April 6, at the 'Jana Jatara' rally near Hyderabad, where Congress leader Rahul Gandhi launched the party campaign, Revanth cautioned KCR against "venting frustration through abusive language", referring to the ex-CM's intemperate remarks against the current dispensation at several public meetings. "We have been maintaining restraint because you lost power, broke your hip bone and your daughter has been jailed. It was a humanitarian gesture. But we are not going to tolerate such talk and canards from KCR," he said, even threatening to send the BRS supremo to Cherlapalli jail. An already em-